Joint Learning Agenda

Strengthening Evidence for Anticipatory Action

Meeting Notes

Joint Learning Agenda for Anticipatory Action (JLAA) — Validation Session

15 October 2026, 13:09 CEST. Duration 1 hour 50 minutes. Online, recorded.

Session overview

The session gathered partners from across the anticipatory action community to validate the draft Joint Learning Agenda and gather a first round of feedback before its launch as a living document at the Global Dialogue Platform in Berlin next October 21. The notes below summarise the presentation, then each contribution from the floor, in the order they were made. For ease of reference, a timeline of the highlights of the session is provided in the annex to facilitate the consultation of the recording.

Thirty participants attended. Colleagues who took the floor or posed questions represented OCHA (Julia Wittig, Hanna Paulose), WFP (Jennifer Waidler, Urbe Secades), ISDC (Jon Kurtz), Prosper Global (Alex Humphrey), Save the Children (Emma Visman, Towhidul Tarafder), the International Rescue Committee (Mikaela Cochran), and the Red Cross Red Crescent Climate Centre and AA MEAL Working Group (Clemens Gros).

Other participants across organisations included the World Bank (Paul J. Christian, Roshni Khincha), the European Commission – DG ECHO (Sarah-Elisabeth Dufau, Sergio Garcia de Diego), FCDO (Howard Standen), the Start Network (Joyce Chan), World Vision (Caitlin Whittemore), Welthungerhilfe (Matthias Amling, Flaminia Mussio), ISDC (Ghassan Baliki), the American Red Cross (Jeanne Crump), the German Red Cross (Arielle Tozier de la Poterie), RWI – Leibniz Institute for Economic Research (Kati Krähnert, Lukas Mogge, Julian Röckert) and WFP (Shirin Merola).

Part 1: Recap Agenda Document presented by the FAO team

Antonio Scognamillo (FAO) opened by setting out where the agenda comes from. It grew out of the April workshop in Rome and was refined through subsequent dialogues with strategic partners. It is now a living document that continues to evolve through partners' feedback.

The central message is that the case for acting early is already made, and the frontier has now moved. The task is no longer to prove that anticipatory action works, but to take the evidence beyond a single project or country and build cumulative evidence body that can inform how programmes are designed.

Subsequently t was clarified what the JLAA is and what is not:

- It is a shared framework, not a platform or a fund. It provides an overarching structure under which each institution's effort is systematised, so that each contribution is magnified (“the whole is greater than the sum of its part”).
- It is open to any organisation that generates, finances or uses anticipatory action evidence. It adds visibility across partners' studies and produces comparable findings aims to act as a catalyst for joint resource mobilisation.
- Partners are encouraged to gradually move toward more joint approaches, while recognising the individual contributions each organisation or institution makes to the agenda through evidence generated within its own mandate and priorities.
- It pursues four objectives: a roadmap for evidence building; a shared reference for tracking progress and expectations; a bridge from evidence to action; and a lever for mobilising additional resources by pooling the existing ones without necessarily sharing budgets.
- Rigorous impact evaluation, other quantitative work and qualitative approaches can all contribute, provided that research question, methodologies, assumptions and limitations are transparent and clearly acknowledged. Evidence produced under the agenda should be decision-relevant, build on what already exists and be proportionate (effort, cost and burden of collecting evidence match its purpose and expected value) and ethical (evidence is generated in a way that respects the rights, safety and dignity of the people involved). Where possible, it should also be comparable by design, using a common measurement module.
- Seven actions follow from the gaps, including a target of at least ten studies by 2030, a common measurement module linked to existing guidelines (e.g., AA MEAL guidelines),

a living inventory of studies, open data under agreed protocols whenever feasible, and stakeholder engagement of donors, governments and communities.

- Governance is deliberately light. All stakeholders define priorities and endorse by consensus, with a core group proposing and reviewing the portfolio. The AA MEAL and AA Task Force groups would act as an informal secretariat so that it is a participatory framework, and not organization specific.
- Financing works on two tiers: individual studies financed by partners, singly or jointly. It also envisions the allocation of a modest, pooled amount for the shared functions run through the MEAL working group.
- Success will be measured by the number of organisations endorsing the agenda, the number of studies in the portfolio, the share of them applying the common measurement framework, the pooled analyses completed across geography and hazards, and the documented cases where evidence informed a programme, scaling or financing decision.

Part 2: Overview of the first round of comments received:

Kamran Khan Niazi (FAO) presented the feedback received on the living document until 13th October which included approximately 46 comments from 10 organisations, grouped by section into eight themes. The themes were:

- Scope and framing: clarify whether the agenda is about what works in anticipatory action or about anticipatory action versus response; broaden to the national-policy perspective and state whether the scope is humanitarian only or also reaches development and climate.
- The four gaps: make them more specific; add one or more explicit targeting questions and a delivery-channel dimension.
- Pathways to long-term outcomes: embed children's outcomes such as nutrition and continuity of education; capture the pathways toward developmental and resilience outcomes; and keep expected long-term effects proportionate to the size of the intervention.
- Cost-effectiveness: distinguish cost-effectiveness from cost-benefit analysis; include the opportunity cost of not acting; compare against long-term investment rather than only emergency response; and account for readiness costs and un-triggered frameworks.

- Coverage and equity: disaggregate by sex, age and disability wherever the data allow, and treat fragile and conflict-affected settings as a knowledge gap rather than an obstacle.
- Governance and coexistence with other initiatives: clarify how the agenda relates to the other existing effort and how NGOs can co-design. Clarify the hosting arrangement and who selects portfolio studies.
- Rigour, standards and data-sharing: the narrative must match the strength of the method; use the MEAL group's common indicators; set minimum methodological standards while allowing a range of study types; and explain why data is shared, while softening the expectation that all data must be shared.

Open discussion to review comments and other suggestions

Niccolò Lombardi (FAO) appreciated everyone’s active participation to the document and many useful comments and opened the floor around four questions: the overall feel of the agenda, what might be missing, whether the four gaps identified are exhaustive, and what must be clarified before the light launch of the living document to the GDP in Berlin. He stressed that the agenda must remain a flexible, living document while setting clear, common targets until the end of the year. Subsequently, the agenda should be formally endorsed so that participants may actively contribute to the objectives toward 2030.

Interventions from the floor:

Emma Visman (Save the Children) 28:48

- The agenda reads as very agency-driven; it should also reflect what communities and governments themselves are learning and doing.
- It reads as very food-security and livelihoods focused; it should broaden to other sectors, especially education and child protection, and consider sensitivity for children and other vulnerable groups.
- The Global Dialogue Platform, and the later East Africa and Asia platforms, could be used to map concrete El Niño opportunities where partners' plans already align, giving donors a committed, practical first step for early 2027.

Jon Kurtz (ISDC) 33:30

- Build in incentives so the agenda does not become a passive registry. Make research easier through pre-positioned common modules, tools and designs; cheaper, perhaps through a small top-up fund for extra sampling or cost analysis; and better, through research-design feedback sessions.
- Offer visibility and influence, giving partners access to stakeholders and audiences they would not otherwise reach. The “value for partners” section could be built out with these points.

Clemens Gros (AA MEAL / Climate Centre) 37:15

- Expressed strong appreciation: the document pulls a great deal of scattered thinking together concisely, and the action areas are tangible and specific.
- The practicalities of who does the work, and the time it requires, are not yet clear. He hoped the FAO team would continue to lead, with the MEAL group assembling coalitions of the willing to work on, for example, the common measurement module, understood as a ready-to-use questionnaire that plugs into a planned survey.

Antonio Scognamillo (FAO) 41:20

- Responded on the question of time: the agenda envisions a modest pooled resource for the shared functions, to compensate the time partners contribute to the common good, allocated within the AA MEAL group.

Julia Wittig (OCHA) 43:14

- Make it as explicit as possible that the agenda builds on existing mechanisms and evaluation structures, given the resource constraints across the system.
- Gently disagreed that the MEAL group has worked “for free”, since salaries are paid by donors; the real challenge has been resourcing the robustness and delivery of studies.
- Comparability is where the agenda can genuinely add value. Much of the indicator feedback is not new; the priority is studies that are comparable and can be aggregated into a joint evidence base.

Jennifer Waidler (WFP) 48:39

- Define standards rather than methods: a strong qualitative study can be more useful than a weak randomised trial, so what makes a good study should be defined under each method.
- This matters both for pooling data and for credibility with donors; widely different cost requests for the same type of study undermine the collective ask.

Towhid ul Islam Tarafder (Save the Children) 51:02

- Consider trigger harmonisation in multi-hazard contexts, where activation is usually based on the primary hazard, but cascading effects also matter.
- Asked about anticipation within a crisis modifier, anticipation as part of development projects in hazardous contexts, and links to government multi-year disaster-risk-management planning.

In response, Niccolò and Antonio noted that anticipatory action links many processes, and that for now the agenda deliberately narrows its focus to whether the actions deliver the expected outcomes, the last part of the chain. Trigger harmonisation is largely background to this agenda, with parallel forecasting efforts already underway across OCHA, WFP, FAO and academia. The balance to strike is between specificity and inclusiveness.

Urbe Secades (WFP) 59:26

- Transform the broad gap questions into comparable clusters, otherwise joint studies will be hard to compare across time, countries and hazards.
- Move toward an implementation plan with targets and timelines so the roll-out becomes tangible.
- On standards, cited WFP's work with the Climate Centre to produce a robustness score, which is transparent about what each method delivers and its limitations, so that a study is not dismissed simply because it is not a randomised trial.

Alex Humphrey (Mercy Corps) 1:05:29

- Welcomed the shift from asking whether anticipatory action works to asking how to make it work better, but felt the agenda could be more deliberate about encouraging decision-ready evidence on specific design features.

- Much current insight on transfer size and structure is inferred rather than tested directly. He encouraged studies that are explicit from the outset about target outcomes and the design choices that drive them, citing the recent FAO Somalia trial on transfer structure as a model.

Hanna Paulose (OCHA) 1:08:58

- Aligned on the goal, but asked the central question: what would each organisation actually do differently under this agenda, given that shared indicators, joint evaluation and the impact evaluation window already exist?
- From setting up the Chad impact evaluation, comparability does not happen simply because it is agreed; it requires dedicated technical capacity and staff time.
- Pushed for more specificity on how standards and quality are maintained, given shrinking resources.
- Questioned prioritising long-term resilience outcomes, since most anticipatory action is short-term and its effects tend to dissipate over time.

In response, Niccolò and Antonio explained that the agenda gives a further push and common targets to work already under way, aiming for a set of joint studies and harmonised methods by 2030, with the Window an important part of these efforts rather than a competitor. Echoing the idea that the sum of the parts is greater than each of them, the agenda puts existing efforts under one umbrella without reinventing the wheel; each organisation sets standards and priorities under its own mandate. On long-term outcomes, the point is not a long-term impact of anticipatory action in isolation, but that it builds on development and resilience efforts; understanding that complementarity is central to the business case for donors and remains a genuine research gap.

Mikaela George (IRC) 1:22:04

- Building on Alex's operational-learning point, encourage a standard approach to cost-efficiency analysis, which tends to be overlooked relative to cost-effectiveness and cost-benefit but matters for testing implementation choices.
- Cost terms are often used interchangeably and must be clearly defined, with transparency about which costs are included and how the data were collected, since cost analysis is far less standardised across organisations than impact evaluation.

Wrap-up and next steps

Antonio and Niccolò (FAO) closed by confirming that all feedback, from the meeting and from the document, would be folded, as much as possible, into a revised version, still a living document, for the Global Dialogue Platform, with further rounds of feedback to follow after the launch. The agreed next steps are:

- Address as many comments as possible before Berlin and launch the JLAA at the Global Dialogue Platform next week, through a parallel session on evidence and a reference in one of the plenary sessions.
- Through late 2026 and early 2027, validate the core questions and processes and build buy-in from as many partners as possible (formal endorsement).
- From 2027 to 2030, the focus will shift to advancing harmonisation and, above all, to filling the remaining evidence gaps. The ambition for 2030 is clear: a shared, cumulative body of evidence, communicated beyond single organisations and projects, that makes anticipatory action not just more cost-effective, but more impactful for the people it serves, reducing their vulnerability to shocks and contributing to pathways toward resilience.

Annex A: Timeline of interventions and speakers

Time	Speaker	Focus
0:00	Antonio Scognamillo, FAO	Presentation of the agenda: purpose, objectives, gaps, actions, governance, financing
15:35	Kamran Khan Niazi, FAO	First round of written feedback: 46 comments, 10 organisations, eight themes
25:32	Niccolò Lombardi, FAO	Opening the floor for discussion
28:48	Emma Visman	Community and government learning; broader sectors; El Niño opportunity
33:30	Jon Kurtz, ISDC	Incentives: what attracts and retains partners
37:15	Clemens Gros	Appreciation; practicalities and time commitment
43:14	Julia Wittig, OCHA	Build on existing structures; comparability as the value-add
48:39	Jennifer Waidler, WFP	Define standards by method; implications for pooling and funding
51:02	Towhidul Tarafder	Trigger harmonisation; multi-hazard; link to government systems
59:26	Urbe Secades, WFP	Cluster the gap questions; implementation plan; research robustness scoring
1:05:29	Alex Humphrey	Encourage decision-ready evidence on design features
1:08:58	Hanna Paulose, OCHA	What changes in practice; specificity on rigour; the long-term outcomes question
1:22:04	Mikaela George	Cost-efficiency analysis; clearer cost definitions
1:27:48	FAO team	Wrap-up and next steps